

Is safety more important than fun?

From the start of humanity, safety was a natural reflex embedded in the brain¹. For survival, animals were naturally forced to learn how to avoid death. From then to the present, human's brains have repeatedly evolved, along with the ability to sense danger. This type of behavior is normally referred to as "safety."

Safety is defined as "a state in which or a place where you are safe and not in danger or at risk²." It is a natural response for humans to sense danger and evacuate; called flight response. Flight response is triggered by the sympathetic nervous systems as soon as the amygdala, a central part of the brain, extinguishes an object or an living organism as a danger^{3,4}. However, the conceptual idea of safety varies from person to person due to their familiarity with an object or an environment. An individual can still feel vulnerable to danger even if they are physically protected due to the way the brain feels uncomfortable in an unfamiliar environment or a situation⁴.

In spite of that, fun is defined as "pleasure, enjoyment, or entertainment⁵." Fun, is another feeling that many organisms feel, due to the release of dopamine and serotonin⁶. This feeling of fun usually occurs in an experience of liberating engagement; in other words, a combination of the feeling of liberation and sensation of pleasantness. Furthermore, fun itself is not deeply connected with external motivations such as money or fame⁷. This is since fun is often connected with having joy or enjoying life rather than achieving a great position or a job. Both fun and safety is an important aspect of life, as to feel relieved and to stay out of danger. Even though safety needs to be strictly followed on many occasions, fun is more essential than safety. In this essay, I will explain the aspects of how fun outweighs the importance of safety.

Regardless of how fun outweighs the importance of safety, safety itself is very essential in daily life. As safety has evolved over thousands of years¹, safety still prevents people from dangers in personal daily activities. Safety is further divided into two categories; workplace safety and personal safety.

Workplace safety is often referred to the environment of a company, especially relating to the safety of employees, so it is important to both employees and employers. For employees, safety is directly related to their well-being and wages as it can cause physical pain, possible loss of life, and decreased income. Each of these three scenarios are unpleasant to the one who encounters safety obstacles, as it affects their health and economical state. For employers, poor workplace safety can lead to inefficient productivity, loss of money due to compensation⁹.

Personal safety, in contrast with workplace safety, highly regards an individual's enjoyment. Examples include such as putting on a seatbelt while riding a car or any other safety acts that includes the risk of an individual's endangerment². This kind of safety is related and is responsible for the individual as it mostly or entirely depends on the individual's choices. Personal safety can be debatable as every individual can have a different standard for safety⁴.

Although safety's importance needs to be embraced in all populations, fun still outweighs the benefits of safety. The effectiveness of safety comes from its power of restriction. Most of the safety guidelines follow the format of "Do's and Don'ts" like how the California COVID-19 protocol does¹⁰. People are prohibited from doing certain acts such as traveling while feeling sick in order to prevent a number of people from getting COVID. However, these kinds of restrictions produce a lot of stress and can affect a person's psychology such as having concentration issues or changes in mood. A recent study related to COVID restrictions revealed that in stressful situations such as restrictions and inability to go out due to safety purposes, people are likely to be sleep deprived. This affects the brain by causing stress like mentioned previously¹¹.

Moreover, safety can worsen one's health. These aspects of safety that appear very coercive to people can lead to stress¹⁹. The effect of stress can be dangerous if it is repeated overly, and can cause symptoms such as headaches, anxiety, lack of focus, fatigue, and pain²⁰. And as stress can affect one's focus, it results in less work efficiency and lack of safety; which are the opposite of what safety intends for people to do.

In relation to the stress caused by safety, restrictions related to safety can also cause depression. With the modern example of COVID, researches show how quarantine and social distancing has made people more depressed. By comparing a control group and a group that went through quarantine in South Korea, the results showed how the group in quarantine had 4% higher levels of depression of 7.8%, and the control group having a depression rate of 3.8%²². Furthermore, the pandemic increased the depression rate of people worldwide by 25%. As it is required for people to be isolated from others in the name of safety, people were not able to have fun by socializing and doing activities together, which was an important part of enjoyment and positive emotions²³.

Furthermore, humans are designed to rebel against a regulation made and follow what they want to do. This kind of behavior is called "psychological reactance." This behavior appears when an individual or a society is facing a threat to their given freedom¹². An example of this can be health campaigns or the safety restrictions, as some people tend to smoke more after being told to smoke less. It cannot be controlled completely in the current society as it is human's natural instinct to react and follow freedom. This shows how having safety prioritized can actually make people do the prohibited acts more, not even reaching its goal. It can be concluded that safety is a threat to freedom as relating to the behavior mentioned.

Having fun appears more important than safety, giving the benefits that safety doesn't encourage. Participating in fun activities or committing an act of fun is able to release hormones such as serotonin, dopamine, and endorphins¹⁴. These three chemicals are all unleashed when an individual feels fun or does a fun activity^{15,16,17}. Moreover, all three make one feel good and benefit other parts of the body when released a normal amount. This includes healing wounds, feeling happy, enhancing memory, improving sleep, boosting the immune system, and encouraging self-esteem. Having fun not only reduces stress, but it also makes people healthier simultaneously.

As the current society is dealt with many problems that affect an individual's depressive state and stress level, the multiple benefits of fun, even the single outcome of fun giving

happiness to people holds importance. People are able to get away from their busy lives and enjoy concentrating on a subject, or a pleasurable activity; away from their burden. This kind of happiness is also the same as Aristotle's epicureanism of not feeling any pressure and feeling happy. Additionally, research has also shown that natural laughs decreased the negative emotions people felt, compared to those who did not, which also suggests how being happy can bring physical health to people.

Fun can also promote social skills. Many "fun activities" considered by people are in a group unit. Few examples of fun activities include team sports such as basketball, hobbies such as board games and video games, and other activities such as book club or escape room. Thus, the interactions with other individuals can develop social skills²¹. Furthermore, it is possible to make friends or close relationships throughout the recreation related to fun that can further develop an individual's life.

In some cases, fun leads to a successful invention of a new act or object. In sports, for example, basketball was invented by a physical education teacher who wanted the students to have fun. The students carried out the game as it was fun, and it soon became a popular sport that everyone can enjoy²⁵. For an object, frisbee is another noticeable example. Frisbee was developed over time by a person named Fred Morrison, who enjoyed throwing lids and cake pans by the fun of that act. This led him to develop a better flying object, which was developed into a frisbee over time²⁶. Represented by these two examples, fun was able to create and introduce sensational inventions to the public. Ultimately, fun spurred creativity and new inventions for the betterment of life.

When comparing and contrasting the priority of safety and fun, it is a highly debatable topic which can be reflected upon a personal choice. However, fun is important in many different ways. As stated, fun is very beneficial to an individual and as a group of people. It aids with mental and physical health of people, encouraging them to socialize and can also end up in creative inventions. The beneficial part of fun needs to be promoted, regardless of the regulations and prohibitions. Even though there are many more beneficial aspects of having fun, safety also needs to be considered during all activities in order for individuals to be safe and promote fun.

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